FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

78 YEARS OF INDEPENDENCE

India won its political independence in 1947, but economic independence in terms of prosperity for the masses of Indians is still work in progress. More than the large corporations, the real momentum will come from the fundamental transformation of the vast 66.7 million micro enterprises spread across the country. They employ 222 million, or 39 per cent of India's workforce of 565 million. That makes them the second largest employer, next only to agriculture, which clocks 254 million or 45 per cent. So, these unheralded entities are foundational to India's economy. On the 78th anniversary of Independence, we focus on this vital entrepreneurial spectrum of the economy. This is not the BSE 100 or the Nifty 50. This is a remarkable set of 24 individuals whom we are calling the Micromoguls. A uniquely creative cohort that represents the millions of unsung entrepreneurs out there, holding before us the transformative promise of small economics.



▲ August 24, 2015



▲ August 24, 2020



▲ August 26, 2024

Their stories are all awash in optimism. Each venture profiled in this issue shows how ingenuity at the grassroots is creating impact and profit at the base of India's economic pyramid. A travelling beekeeper like Gajanan Bhalerao is following a personal passion, but also breathing new life into some 80,000 plots of farmland—restoring them to ecological health. Tariq Ahmad Ganie is cleaning up rural Kashmir of toxic waste and making money out of it. Gujarat's Arjit Soni, who runs a Rs 9 crore bicycle rental, is putting up a blueprint for India's creaking public transport. Nabamita Bhattacharya's Buddy Back Home in Kolkata boasts a turnover of only Rs 1.25 crore. It employs only 30 full-time staff. But the value these 'buddies' bring to 300-plus lonely elderly lives is beyond quantification.

A striking commonality binds these ventures. They are not NGOs, but profitable businesses. Yet, almost all are inextricably tied to the social and ecological realities, showing a profound awareness of the India they operate in. Consider the Ramakrishna couple who run Rang De, an NBFC that makes affordable microcredit accessible. Whether you measure it by its Rs 3.6 crore turnover, or the Rs 96.7 crore from 11,123 social investors that have flowed to 26,516 micro-entrepreneurs, the impact is unmistakable. Or take Iaishah Rymbai, a 48-year-old divorcee and single mother of four in Meghalaya's Kdonghulu village. Her Rs 30 lakh EriWeave initiative is reviving indigenous silk traditions, unlocking digital markets, and offering meaningful income to over 200 women. The figures may appear small, but the transformation is priceless.

India's 67.1 million MSMEs contribute 30 per cent to GDP, 36 per cent to manufacturing and 45 per cent to exports. Among them, micro enterprises account for 99 per cent of the total number, with significant employment capacity. To revitalise this crucial segment, which has been bruised by a series of shocks, from demonetisation to the pandemic, the government has scaled up its support mechanisms. The Credit Guarantee Scheme was revamped in April, doubling turnover limits and offering collateral-free loans of up to Rs 1 crore. Since 2014, the number of guarantees under the scheme has jumped nearly tenfold. Alongside, schemes such as Mudra and credit-linked technology subsidies are also widening access to capital.

Still, these initiatives cannot mask the enduring frustration of entrepreneurs who struggle to navigate an archaic system. Despite the promise of 'ease of doing business', too many still face a tangle of rules at the grassroots, at the state, district and taluka levels. Many in our story have battled these odds and triumphed. But systemic reform is overdue. The "Next Gen" reforms the Prime Minister referenced in his Independence Day speech must become a reality urgently. That is the only way millions more can find their footing, just as the GreenSole Foundation does in one of our stories: fashioning new shoes for India to walk towards a brighter future.



(Aroon Purie)